Bhonsle (Devashish Makhija) and *Gali Guleiyan* (Dipesh Jain). Says Bajpayee, "People who are experimenting with the medium are the ones I love the most. I get an opportunity to explore new things through my craft and it helps me to grow as an actor." Finding distribution for these films continues to be hard, but it doesn't deter Bajpayee from doing "things purely for yourself, for the love of acting and cinema". Cinema, he adds, is an art form first.

That's not to say there's "malice" for commercial cinema. His filmography is a testament to that. His request before he signs the dotted line is simple. "I am always requesting them to come up with a concrete story and solid character so that I can surprise myself and the audience at the same time," says Bajpayee.

Until that happens, 2023 will see Bajpayee in more indie films: *Joram* with Makhija, *Despatch* with Kanu Behl (*Titli*) and an untitled one with Raam Reddy (*Thithi*). Where they will appear—at a festival, on the big screen or a streaming platform—is not known. But it is on the last of those that the actor is currently thriving and expanding his fan base. For many, he's not the compelling Bhiku Mhatre of *Satya*, but the endearing Srikant Tiwari of *The Family Man*. Later this year, he features alongside Konkona Sen Sharma in the Netflix series *Soup* helmed by Abhishek Chaubey. Bajpayee on his part is relishing each second of his busy calendar. "It took me three decades to come to a place where I am finally getting choices," he says. "I hope and pray that they don't stop." Given what he's capable of, it's a win-win for both the creators and the audiences. ■

Suhani Singh

MURDERS SHE SOLVED

Web series about serial killers are rare in India, but **Sonakshi Sinha**-starrer ***Dahaad*** takes a stab at the genre

Crime has been a staple of Indian web series, but few creators have attempted one set around a serial killer (Voot Select's *Asur* and ZEE5's *Duranga* come closest). Enter Reema Kagti and Zoya Akhtar, whose second show, *Dahaad* (streaming on Prime Video), involves a bunch of police officers following the trail of one. A slow burn of a crime drama, it's one where the audience is always two steps ahead of the police and the thrills and twists are few and far between.

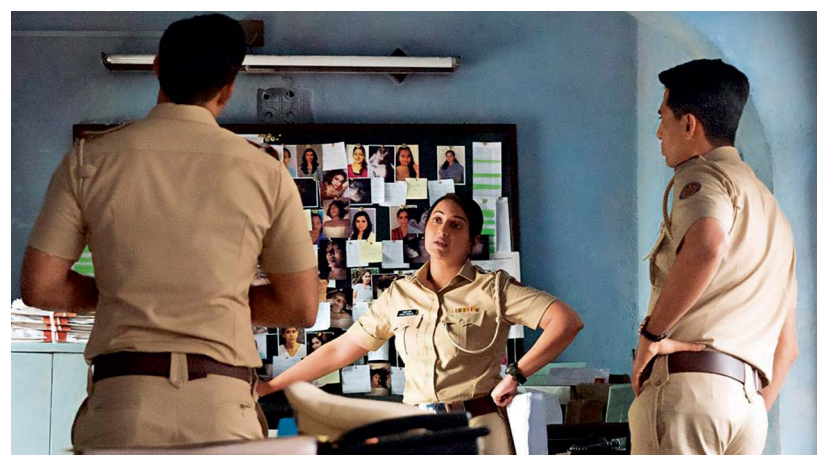
It's not for lack of trying. Sonakshi Sinha, who learned judo, bike riding and a Rajasthani dialect to play Anjali Bhaati a.k.a. 'Bhaati Saheb', the sole woman in the police station, battles casteism and patriarchy while leading an investigation to hunt down a smooth-talking predator who lures women into running away with him under the pretext of marriage. The said serial killer is essayed with understated flair by Vijay Varma, by far the show's most impressive character despite the script not offering an entirely convincing set-up for his motivations and ability to pull off his many crimes. Varma consulted a psychiatrist to break down the "twisted mind". "They [serial killers] are good at lying and being invisible when they want," says Varma.

DAHAAD is a slow burn of a crime drama, where the audience is always two steps ahead of the police

Set in Mandawa, a small town in Rajasthan, Kagti and Akhtar use the backdrop to highlight the fault lines of caste and religion in the region, which leads to some half-hearted socio-cultural commentary. Sinha and her superiors, played by Gulshan Devaiah and Sohum Shah, are pressured to intimidate a young Muslim man who has married the Hindu daughter of an influential politician. For Varma, who has earlier collaborated with Akhtar and Kagti on *Gully Boy*, it showcases the filmmakers' need "to send a bigger message through the cinema they are making".

Not every crime drama has to be a whodunit or adhere to the tropes of the genre, but *Dahaad* fails to lure audiences into its police procedural. As the body count rises (credit to Kagti and Ruchika Oberoi for avoiding the blood and gore) and the catch-me-if-you-can drama drags on, the plot gets repetitive and tiring. It doesn't help that the personal arcs of the three officers—the men feud with their wives while Sinha's Anjali contends with an overbearing mother (Jayati Bhatia in a thankless role)—don't add much meat to the proceedings. By episode six, *Dahaad* struggles to stay afloat as all the characters do is keep giving instructions to each other to follow leads. It comes down to Varma to do much of the heavy lifting as he demonstrates how not all serial killers need to be deranged and creepy. The menacing killer could very well be the regular family-man next door. ■

Suhani Singh



▼ **POLICE PROCEDURAL**
Sonakshi Sinha in a still from *Dahaad* (Prime Video)